



long tail used for
balance when
leaping

Verreaux's sifaka

Propithecus verreauxi

One of the largest members of the lemur family, the Verreaux's sifaka lives in the dry and spiny forests of south and southwest Madagascar. Sifakas are active during the daytime, feeding in trees—mainly on leaves, flowers, and fruit. They extract moisture from the leaves of succulent plants or by licking water droplets that have condensed on their woolly fur.

In leaps and bounds

Sifakas venture to the ground to cross open spaces in their distinctive bipedal leaping gait. In the trees, they move by clinging vertically and leaping with their long, strong hindlegs, covering gaps of up to 33 ft (10 m). Although their large hands and feet can be used for grasping, sifakas rarely use them in feeding. Instead they lean the whole body forward and pick up food directly with the mouth. Females are dominant in sifaka social groups. Groups of sifakas tend to spread out while traveling and searching for food, but come together in the same tree to rest.

Sifakas live in small groups of a few females and two or three males, one of which may be a “stain-chested” male, so-called because it produces scent from a gland in its throat which it uses in marking. All sifakas scent-mark their territories with urine and use it to signal to members of their own social group. They also communicate through calls, including a barklike “shi-fak” call which gave them their name.

Like many lemurs, the Verreaux's sifaka is at risk from destruction of its habitat due to slash-and-burn agriculture and timber felling.

About **30 percent** of
Verreaux's sifakas
are **killed by fosas**
in their **first year**

